

Strategic Hamlets

After two years of growing insurrection in the South Vietnamese countryside, pressure mounted on Diem to devise an effective counterinsurgency strategy. His answer was the Strategic Hamlets Program.

◀◀ BEFORE

The Viet Cong's influence in rural areas had long been a problem for the Diem regime.

THE AGROVILLES

As early as 1959, Diem began moving South Vietnam's rural population from their ancestral homes to **fortified villages**, called agrovilles, to isolate them from the influence of communists and protect them from attack. The villagers resented the move, especially since the regime forced them to buy the land. No more than 20 agrovilles were ever completed and the South Vietnamese government had abandoned the scheme by 1961.

The idea of moving villagers to specially fortified hamlets to protect them from the Viet Cong was promoted by Sir Robert Thompson, the leader of a British advisory mission to Vietnam. The British had contained a rebellion in their colony, Malaya, by employing a similar scheme. In Vietnam, it was envisaged that ARVN troops would provide protection for the hamlets until locally trained self-defense militias could take over. At the same time, economic and social reforms would also help to win the villagers' trust.

Thompson had misread the Vietnamese situation. In Malaya, the majority of insurgents were of Chinese origin, not Malayan. The Vietnamese were being asked to take up arms against their fellow countrymen. Furthermore, in Malaya, the British had fortified existing villages, not constructed new ones. The Vietnamese version of the plan entailed a large-scale displacement of villagers that only added to the prevailing discontent with Diem's government.